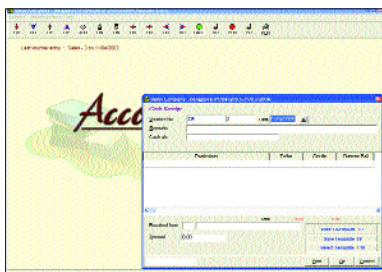


Accounts 21

Accounts 21 is the fastest in terms of data entry. Anybody with basic knowledge of accounting, and familiarity with Windows, can get straight to work. Accounts 21 comes in a range of variants like accounting only, accounting plus, invoicing plus multi-currency, etc. In all, there are five variants of the product.

The layout of the software is impressive: There are one-touch buttons for common operations such as Cash Receipt, Bank Receipt, Cash-To-Cash, Bank-To-Bank, etc. This software has some cool features such as ready-to-use accounting templates for different business categories, and a document designer for voucher designing.



There are advanced features such as Cost Centre-wise Accounting, Ratio Analysis, Cash and Fund Flow Statements, etc. Reports can be based on credit limit and outstanding, in addition to basic reports such as

Trial Balance, PNL, and Balance Sheet. There are some good features relating to vouchers too. For example, locking and unlocking of vouchers for a period, voucher re-numbering, and customising voucher format. If you're sure about a transaction that has not yet occurred, planned vouchers can be used; this entry stays afloat until the transaction happens, and the respective accounts will then show the desired results.

In the reports section, there's a previewing facility, and there's the option to print reports in graphical or text mode. Accounts 21 can generate reports based on specific periods. It provides exporting of report data in the .csv format, so that it can then be used with spreadsheet applications. Help is built-in, and there are no manuals.

Accounts 21 comes at a rock-bottom price of Rs 999 for the Single Company version. This is a good version to start with—you can upgrade as volumes increase.

Price: Rs 999
+ Simple; easy to use
- Not too many features

Accounts 21 B+	
Performance	▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶
Features	▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶
Ease of Use	▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶
Overall	▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶

ACE 7.0

ACE 7.0 provides several valuation methods for generating pricing. Another, related feature is re-order level and re-order quantity, which help keep a check on available stock.

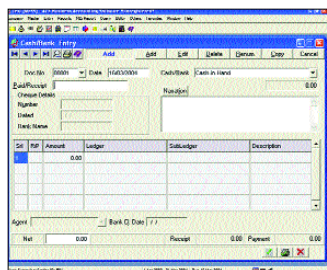
Printing reports, as well as the facility to export data to popular office applications is common, but exporting into HTML is a feature only ACE has. Likewise, e-mailing reports directly to a contact.

The layout of the software isn't too good. The inbuilt help isn't sufficient, either. ACE does come with some useful features such as online bill adjustment, customisable voucher numbers, date-wise locking, credit days and credit limit facility both for debtors as well as creditors, multiple unit support as well as conversion between the units automatically based on ratio, aging report, sale or purchase price list, etc.

Another good feature is that while creating a chart of accounts, ACE lists groups in different tabs, categorising them—thereby making it easier to search or navigate.

The software is not free of

“Basic accounting is difficult, though features are manifold. Also, expensive”



Price: Single user—Rs 13,200; 5-user—Rs 25,300
+ Online bill adjustment, date-wise locking, customisable aging report
- Lacks ratio analysis, cash flow and fund flow; lacks year-end balance confirmation format; naive layout

ACE 7.0 B+	
Performance	▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶
Features	▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶
Ease of Use	▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶
Overall	▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶

bugs: For example, if you add a new entry, it's not reflected immediately; you'll need to restart the chart of accounts. Similarly, if your computer doesn't have a printer driver installed, the software won't open reports; it just prints an error message and aborts the operation.

Although the software has pretty good features, some basic programming flaws make it lose ground. We believe a patch should be released.

Online Accounting

There aren't too many companies in the online accounting area; one that provides this facility is IndiaAccounts. Using online accounting, you can update and check the status of your finances anytime and anywhere. All data resides on a Web server, so you need never worry about data loss.

There's a subscription fee. With IndiaAccounts the fee is yearly; its Rs 200 for individuals and Rs 750 for SMEs. With the multiple login feature for SMEs, there's the possibility of debating your financial situation with accountants, each sitting in his office or home.

IndiaAccounts provides three modules—Accounting, Inventory and Payroll. Your accountant can observe daily transactions as and when they happen, while supervising entries, allowing or disallowing entries. For accountants it's an even better service, as one can manage entries of more than one individual simultaneously. The Web site doesn't provide advanced features, though. It just provides a vanilla version of the Accounting, Inventory and the Payroll modules. You can't export data to office applications. But one nice thing is that a BSE 30 ticker appears in front with the latest quotes.